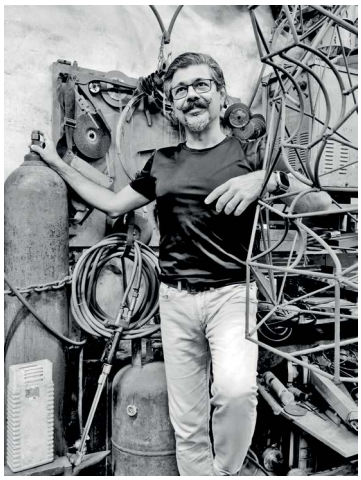
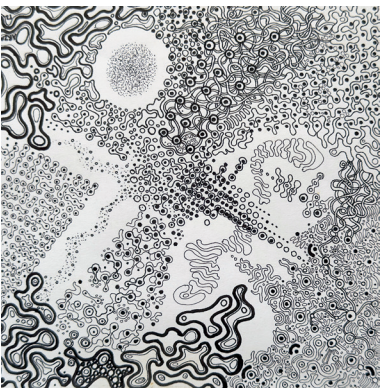




go with the flow," he says, adding that it is about what he felt within that poured out on paper. "They are a reflection of what is going on within me. It is like mapping the mind and what it is subconsciously thinking," he says.

The compositions themselves range from architecturally structured to organically fluid. Together, they form a lyrical quality which matches the wild poetry of the Pink Floyd song, 'Learning to Fly', from which the title has been taken. There are splashes of bright blues and pinks on the mostly monochromatic drawings, adding another dimension to the canvas. Some of them have been burnt and have a reflective surface at the back, so when one is viewing it, they can also see a reflection of themselves within the drawings. The artist has used pens with different thickness to add yet another layer to the works. There are parts that are dark and bold, and some that you have to go close to notice.

Being a sculptor, Khambatta has applied all that he learnt about composition to these works. "In a way, these drawings are the 2D expressions of my 3D work," he says. However, the process of making these drawings is in complete contrast to his sculptures—another reason he enjoys doing them so much. "With my sculptures, I have to pre-plan, give the sketch to the client and get approval," he says. The noise and heat generated from the grinders and welding machines adds to the intensity of the process. When it comes to his drawings, however, he can just immerse himself in a peaceful state, put on some music and draw whatever comes to his mind. "This contrast fascinates me," he shares.

SUSPENDED ANIMATION is on till February 28 at Gallery Art & Soul, Mumbai

Needless to say, it was Pink Floyd that he listened to a lot during the process. "They are the gods of music for me and I find so much meaning in their lyrics. The line from their song 'Learning to Fly'—'There's no sensation to compare with this suspended animation, a state of bliss'—resonates with me each time I do something which brings me joy. Working on these drawings was like being in a state of bliss and time seemed to be suspended. The words fit in beautifully with these works," he adds. ■

–Deepali Dhingra

On the Cusp of the Eighth Day is on at Mumbai's Gallery XXL (21, Arsiwala Mansion First Floor, Wodehouse Road, Colaba), until February 28, 2025. Sarah Malik, curator, Gallery XXL, explains, "The title is from the story of Aravan's sacrifice, the central deity of the Aravanis. This sacrifice, which is vital for the victory of the Pandavas in the 18-day Kurukshetra war, becomes a pivotal point for the transgender community to get together and celebrate the 18-day Koovagam festival. The symbolic sacrifice puts forth different dualities at the stroke of midnight—binding the doubleness of how gender, gender identity, gender expression and sexuality is perceived and lived."

The exhibition is an evocative explosion of emotion. Be prepared to be blown away by the bold colours, vibrant lines and a certain poignance through canvases, photographs, mixed media works, testimonies and intersectional narratives. The diptych,

The exhibition, *On the Cusp of the Eighth Day*, is an evocative explosion of emotion. Be prepared to be blown away by the bold colours...

'Leisurely Saree', uses a collage of acrylic and textile on canvas to start you on a journey into the mindscape of India's transgenders, seeming to invite you in with a soothing cup of tea and gentle chitchat. A trio of paintings, acrylic on canvas, entice you into the externals of their existence, the face they create to face the world. You're drawn ever deeper into the rituals and mythology that the community is immersed in, from a bangle festival in Bannerghata near Bengaluru, to constellations, gods and goddesses being invoked for a measure of hope and happiness. Images by Chennai-based photographer Steevez offer a glimpse into the little joys of safe spaces in Tamil Nadu's state housing for transgender individuals.

There are also attempts to change the narrative like with the clap, which has come to symbolise India's transgender community. It is being redefined as their newly found voice, one that is not always strident, but contemplative and confident in its own skin. Or the reflective acrylic-on-canvas works 'Prathi-Bimba (One's Own Reflection) Mirror Episode 1' and 'Purush-Purushi, Mirror Episode 2', which emphasise the message 'Indeterminate is also a way of being and thriving'. ■

–Priya Pathiyan